# The No Hug Rule

## By Cheryl Costello-Forshey

## INTRODUCTION

*Women everywhere seem to say the same thing about their male partners and it goes like this: 'He just shuts off to emotion! He never tells me how he is feeling!' Or 'He'll leave the room and refuse to talk about it!' There is an unspoken rule that we boys learn very early . . . . Don't cry, don't hug . . . . be a man! It's been said however (and this applies to men and women) that you need four hugs a day for survival, eight for maintenance, and twelve for growth. This poem by Cheryl Costello-Forshey traces the development of "The No Hug Rule," and the ability of one young man to overcome society's implied expectations.*

The first day of kindergarten

He hurried to the door

Shrugging off his mother's hugs

He didn't need them anymore

For he was all grown up now

Too big for all that stuff

Instead he waved a quick good-bye

Hoping that would be enough

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When he came home from school that day

She asked what he had done

He handed her a paper

With a big round yellow sun

A picture quite imperfect

For he'd messed up here and there

But she didn't seem to notice

Or she didn't seem to care

The first day of junior high

He hurried to the door

Running from his mother's hugs

He didn't want them anymore

He ignored her calling out to him

As he hurried down the street

Near the intersection

Where his friends had planned to meet

He hoped that she would understand

Why he had to walk to school

Riding with his mother

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Just wouldn't have been cool

And when he came home from school
She asked what he had done
He handed her some papers
With Xs marked on more than one
The teacher clearly pointing out
The wrong answers here and there
But his mother didn't seem to notice
Or she didn't seem to care

The first day of senior high
He hurried out the door
Jumped into the driver's seat
Of his jacked-up shiny Ford
He left without his breakfast
He left without a word
But he turned and looked back
Before pulling from the curb
He saw her waving frantically
As he drove away

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He tapped his horn just once
To brighten up her day
He saw a smile cross her face
And then he drove from sight
Onward to a different world
A new exciting life

And at his graduation
As tears shone in her eyes
He knew the time had come
To bid his mom good-bye
For he was off to college
Off to better days
No more rules to abide
Alone to find his way

Suitcases filled the trunk
Of his dirty beat-up Ford
He couldn't wait to get to school
To check out his room and dorm
She opened up his car door

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Closed it when he got in
Then smiled proudly at her son
As tears dropped from her chin
She reached through the open window
Wished him luck in school
And then she pulled him close to her
And broke the "no hug" rule
He felt the freedom greet him
As he pulled out on the interstate
At last his life was his alone
He anticipated fate

College life was more challenging
Than he ever could have hoped
There was no time to respond to letters
His mother often wrote
He was a grown adult now
Too old for all that stuff
His visits during holidays
Would have to be enough
Besides, midterms were quickly coming

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The pressure was immense
He studied late into the night
His need to pass intense
He wondered how he'd manage
How he'd ever cope
What if he failed his tests?
Would there be no hope?

As if he had a calling
He headed down the interstate
Driving at full speed
The hour getting late
He pulled up the curb
Where once he used to roam
And went through the open door
Of his mother's home
She was sitting at the table
With a drawing in a frame
Memories from the past
That brought both joy and pain
She didn't need to ask

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Why he was home from school
Because she knew the answer
When he broke the "no hug" rule
HIs arms around her tightly
Peering at the drawing he had done
Lots of trees, imperfect branches
And a big round yellow sun
She smiled a knowing smile
And then she spoke aloud
"Son you always did
And you always will make me very proud
For look how far you've traveled
From that little boy so brave
Heading off to kindergarten
Your hand up in a wave
And through the years you've made mistakes
But son I've made them, too
Being perfect is not an option in life
Simply do the best you can do
And don't expect more than that
For life is supposed to be fun

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You've only got one to live
Do what is best for you son"

Sitting in his dorm room
When the pressure seems too much
And all that he is striving for
Seems completely out of touch
He peers at the drawing
Of a big round yellow sun
And then he is reminded
Of just how far he's come
From childhood to manhood
Fighting back many a fear
Through trials and tribulations
Holding back many a tear
Knowing that being successful
Isn't passing every test
And the only way to falter in life
Is by failing to do his best
And the biggest lesson he's learned
One he did not learn in school...

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That it's okay, for even a man

To break the "no hug" rule

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Costello-Forshey, Cheryl***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2006 National Qualifier***

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